







LOOKING WITHIN (clockwise from top left) Self-portraits by V. Ramesh, Jyoti Bhatt, Sudhir Patwardhan and Gulammohammed Sheikh

ART

SPOTLIGHT ON THE SELF

GALLERY THRESHOLD MARKS ITS 25TH ANNIVERSARY WITH ***REFLECTING THE SELF***, AN AMBITIOUS GROUP SHOW THAT TURNS THE GAZE INWARDS

Artists interact with the world around them through their art. On occasion, they themselves serve as subject and inspiration. Gallery Threshold, in a landmark exhibition to mark its 25th anniversary, puts the spotlight on 'self-representation' by bringing together the works of 35 multi-generational artists who have had an ongoing association with the gallery. *Reflecting the Self* has been curated jointly by the gallery's curator and director Tunty Chauhan and independent curator Deeksha Nath. The works comprise paintings, sculptures, installations, photography and mixed media.

Among sub-genres of art, the self-portrait stands apart. "It's always easier to look out and far more difficult to look within," says Chauhan. "It was not an easy show to put together."

Perhaps that's why the exhibition does not restrict itself to the classical definition of self-portraiture. "We have embraced a broader understanding of self-representation to include abstract and metaphorical references," says Chauhan. "We wanted to include several artists whom we have worked with over the years. Some like Rajendra Dhawan, Surinder and Priya Ravish Mehra have passed on. Many living artists, including T. Vaikuntam and Paramjit Singh, felt they are identified by their work, so we broadened the curatorial premise to include self-representational works."

Although it's difficult to pick favourites among artists one has had a long association with, some artworks do stand out for Chauhan. "My mother's portrait—done on a letter that my father had written to her during the 1962 war—holds a special place for me. She is an artist who formally trained herself at the age of 75 and we did her solo at the age of 80 at Threshold," she says. "Gulammohammed Sheikh's self-portrait captures an entire life span. V. Ramesh's honest portrait in watercolour looks at his existence critically." Apart from these, the exhibition features several major artists, including Amit Ambalal, Chittrovanu Mazumdar, Krishen Khanna, K.G. Subramanyan, Atul and Anju Dodiya, Rameshwar and Shobha Broota, and so on.

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Founded by Chauhan in Visakhapatnam in 1997, Gallery Threshold moved to Delhi in 2001, operating out of multiple spaces before settling down in the leafy environs of Sarvodaya Enclave in New Delhi. The current exhibition showed at Bikaner House before it moved to the gallery. "The fact that this subject has never been handled on this scale goes to show that it's not a comfortable or easy subject," says Chauhan. "It is probably for this reason that some of my dearest friends from the art world are not part of the show." ■

Amit Dixit

Reflecting the Self showed at Bikaner House, New Delhi, from August 18-28. The exhibition continues at Gallery Threshold, C-221, Sarvodaya Enclave, New Delhi, from September 2-15